

BPO / Call Centre Interview Question Bank

Scenario-Based Questions · With Model Answers

AHT	Time Management	People Management	FCR	CSAT
DSAT	Performance Management	Shrinkage	Attrition	
Topics Covered	9			
Total Questions	30+			
Format	Scenario-Based			
Level	Team Leader / Operations Manager			

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Average Handle Time (AHT)

Metric: Talk Time + Hold Time + After Call Work

01

DEFINITION

AHT measures the average duration of a customer interaction end-to-end, including talk time, hold time, and after-call work (ACW). It is a core operational efficiency metric used by WFM for staffing models.

FORMULA

$$\text{AHT} = (\text{Total Talk Time} + \text{Total Hold Time} + \text{Total ACW}) \text{ divided by Total Calls Handled}$$

Example: $(600 + 120 + 80) \text{ mins} / 100 \text{ calls} = 8.0 \text{ minutes AHT}$

Q1 | DIAGNOSIS

Your team's AHT has increased by 45 seconds over the past two weeks. Calls, volume, and product remain unchanged. Walk me through how you would identify the root cause.

Model Answer

Start by disaggregating AHT into its three components — talk time, hold time, and ACW — to identify where the increase is concentrated. Pull the data at both team and individual agent level to determine whether this is a systemic or isolated issue.

- If hold time is up: Investigate navigation issues, system slowness, or process complexity. Check if a recent tool or system change is causing agents to put customers on hold more frequently.
- If talk time is up: Listen to call recordings for patterns — are agents spending more time explaining a new policy, dealing with complex issues, or struggling with call control?
- If ACW is up: Check if a new CRM step, wrap code, or documentation requirement was introduced. Also look at whether new agents are joining the team skewing the average.
- Agent-level analysis: If only 2–3 agents are driving the spike, the root cause is individual coaching gaps. If all agents are affected equally, it is a process or system problem.

Present your findings to management with data visualization (trend chart by component) and a specific action plan addressing the identified root cause.

Q2 | COACHING DILEMMA

An agent's AHT is 30% above the team average, but their CSAT scores are the highest on the floor. How do you address this with them?

Model Answer

This is a quality vs. efficiency trade-off, and it requires a balanced, data-led coaching conversation — not a directive to simply 'be faster.'

- Acknowledge excellence first: Open by recognising their outstanding CSAT. This validates their approach and sets a collaborative tone.
- Use call listening together: Identify specific moments in calls where time could be saved without sacrificing quality — for example, reducing filler phrases, using shorter verification scripts, or leveraging keyboard shortcuts for ACW.
- Set a collaborative target: Rather than imposing the team average, agree on a realistic improvement target (e.g., reduce by 60–90 seconds over 4 weeks) that maintains their CSAT above threshold.
- Benchmark and replicate: Document what makes their quality so high and consider using them as a calibration model or buddy coach for newer agents.

The goal is not to make them average — it is to make them efficient without losing what makes them exceptional.

Q3 | MANAGEMENT PRESSURE

Management wants you to reduce AHT by 20% in 30 days to improve capacity. What steps would you take, and what risks would you flag?

Model Answer

A 20% AHT reduction in 30 days is an aggressive target. Your plan must be structured, data-driven, and include a risk register for leadership.

- ACW reduction (quickest win): Introduce call summary templates, standardize wrap codes, and train agents on efficient note-taking. This typically yields 30–60 seconds of savings with low risk.
- Hold time reduction: Audit what agents search for during holds. Improve knowledge base accessibility, add quick-reference guides, and review frequently consulted resources for consolidation.
- Talk time improvement: Run call control workshops focusing on structured call openings, probing efficiently, and confident closures. Use call listening examples.
- Risk — FCR impact: Rushing agents can cause incomplete resolutions, increasing repeat contacts and negating capacity gains. Monitor FCR weekly as a lagging indicator.
- Risk — CSAT impact: Customers who feel rushed give lower satisfaction scores. Ensure quality audit scores remain stable throughout the initiative.

Recommend presenting a phased plan: quick wins in week 1–2 (ACW/holds), and sustainable talk time coaching in weeks 3–4, with clear metrics and checkpoints.

Q4 | REAL-TIME FLOOR

During a peak hour you notice 3 agents with AHT exceeding 15 minutes on simple queries. What immediate action do you take?

Model Answer

Real-time floor management requires fast triage. The priority is resolving the immediate service level impact while protecting the customer experience.

- Silent listen or barge-in: Immediately listen to at least one of the three calls without interrupting to assess whether it is a knowledge gap, customer complexity, or system issue.
- System check: If all three agents are affected simultaneously, suspect a system or tool outage. Check with IT or your WFM team for any known issues.
- Gentle floor intervention: If it is a knowledge gap, send a quick chat message or floor walk to the agent offering support — do not disrupt the call.
- Queue management: Alert WFM of the potential service level risk. Consider pulling agents from lower-priority tasks to supplement the queue.

Post-shift, run a debrief with the three agents individually. Identify if there is a training gap, a new query type emerging, or a recurring system issue, and address it before the next peak period.

Time Management

Managing shift operations, scheduling, and personal productivity

02

Q1 | STAFFING CRISIS

You have 20 agents on shift, a heavy call queue, and 4 agents are on scheduled breaks. Two agents call in sick. How do you manage the next 2 hours?

Model Answer

This is a real-time staffing gap scenario. The priority order is: protect service level, communicate transparently, and escalate if needed.

- Immediate: Stagger the remaining scheduled breaks — delay non-critical breaks by 15–30 minutes to keep more agents available during the queue spike.
- Voluntary overtime: Quickly canvas agents who are ending their shift or on off-days for voluntary coverage. Even 2–3 additional agents can significantly reduce queue pressure.
- WFM escalation: Inform your Workforce Management team immediately. They can adjust real-time staffing, trigger contingency plans, or move agents from lower-volume queues.
- Task suspension: Temporarily suspend non-call activities (coaching sessions, reports, admin) and redirect those agents to the queue.
- Communication: Update the team on the situation and the temporary plan. Transparency reduces stress and maintains team morale during the crisis.

Document the incident post-shift and review the contingency plan with HR/WFM to prevent recurrence.

Q2 | PRIORITY CONFLICT

You have a team huddle scheduled, a pending PIP document to complete, and a sudden spike in call volume. How do you prioritize?

Model Answer

Prioritization in operations follows a clear hierarchy: live service > people development > administrative tasks.

- Service level first: A sudden volume spike directly impacts customer experience and SLA. Defer the huddle and redirect your attention to the floor. Communicate the change to your team immediately.
- Huddle: Reschedule within the same day or early the next shift. Brief your team with a quick 3-minute standing update if absolutely necessary, rather than cancelling entirely.
- PIP documentation: This is important but not time-sensitive to the hour. Complete it after service level stabilizes — typically during post-peak or your planning time block.

The key skill demonstrated here is triage — knowing the difference between urgent and important, and communicating changes proactively rather than reactively.

Q3 | AGENT PUNCTUALITY

An agent is repeatedly late returning from breaks, causing service level to dip. You've mentioned it informally twice. What's your next step?

Model Answer

Informal conversations have not produced the desired behaviour change. The next step is a formal, documented coaching intervention.

- Formal 1-on-1: Schedule a structured conversation with the agent. Present the data — specific dates, times, and the service level impact. Be factual, not emotional.
- Understand root cause: Before applying consequences, explore whether there is a personal, health, or workspace-related reason. Empathy is not an excuse for non-compliance, but it is context.
- Clear expectations: Restate the break schedule policy, the expected return time, and the consequence of continued non-compliance (written warning / formal disciplinary process).
- Document: Record the conversation, the agreed expectations, and a review date in writing. Share a copy with HR and the agent.
- Follow-up: Monitor adherence closely for the next 2 weeks. Acknowledge improvement or escalate to written warning if the behaviour continues.

Q4 | SELF-MANAGEMENT

You manage coaching, reporting, escalations, and floor walking simultaneously each day. Describe how you structure your time to ensure nothing falls through.

Model Answer

Effective self-management as a Team Leader requires deliberate time-blocking and disciplined prioritization.

- Pre-shift (15 mins): Review overnight reports, check staffing, flag any pending escalations or critical agent issues for the day.
- Peak hours: Floor walking, real-time monitoring, and queue management. Coaching and reporting are deprioritized during peak.
- Off-peak blocks: Dedicate 30-minute protected slots for 1-on-1 coaching sessions, call listening, and performance reviews.
- Reporting: Use dashboards and automated reports to reduce manual data pulling. Set a fixed daily time slot (e.g., post-peak) for report completion.
- Escalations: Handle immediately if critical (DSAT, complaint, policy breach). Route non-critical escalations to a designated queue and batch-process them.

Delegation to senior agents or floor walkers for routine monitoring allows the TL to focus on higher-value activities like coaching and development.

People Management

Conflict, motivation, development, and underperformance

03

Q1 | TEAM CONFLICT

Two top-performing agents are in a visible conflict that is affecting team morale. Neither wants to escalate formally. How do you handle this?

Model Answer

Interpersonal conflict between high performers is particularly sensitive — mishandling it risks losing talent, not just resolving a dispute.

- Separate 1-on-1s first: Meet each agent privately. Listen fully without judgment. Understand each perspective before drawing any conclusions.
- Identify the root cause: Is it a workload issue, a perceived unfairness, a communication misunderstanding, or a competition for recognition? The root cause determines the intervention.
- Joint mediation (with consent): If both parties are open to it, facilitate a structured joint conversation with ground rules — focused on behaviour and impact, not personalities.
- Agree a working protocol: Co-create agreed behaviours for how they will interact professionally going forward. Document this outcome.
- Monitor team impact: Check in with other team members informally to assess morale. Avoid letting the conflict become a topic of team gossip.

Do not avoid this because they are top performers. Unresolved conflict normalizes toxic team dynamics and accelerates attrition in the surrounding team.

Q2 | LOW MORALE

After a sudden process change, your team's engagement drops and several agents express frustration publicly. What do you do?

Model Answer

Change resistance is a normal human response, especially when the 'why' behind the change has not been communicated clearly. The TL's role is to be a credible bridge between leadership and the team.

- Acknowledge and validate: Hold a team session where you openly acknowledge that the change has caused disruption. Never dismiss frustration — it escalates disengagement.
- Explain the 'why': Share the business rationale behind the change to the extent you are authorised to. Agents who understand the purpose are significantly more likely to comply.
- Collect concerns with solutions: Invite agents to share specific concerns, but pair each concern with a question: 'What would make this easier?' This shifts the energy from complaint to problem-solving.
- Escalate genuine concerns: If the feedback identifies real operational flaws in the new process, escalate to management with data and proposed improvements — not just complaints.
- Recognize early adopters: Publicly acknowledge agents who adapt well and model the new behaviour. Peer influence accelerates broader adoption.

Q3 | AGENT DEVELOPMENT

A high-potential agent is showing signs of disengagement and looking for growth. Your org currently has no open TL roles. What do you do?

Model Answer

Career growth does not require a promotion. The risk of inaction is losing a high performer to a competitor — which costs significantly more than a creative retention strategy.

- Have an honest conversation: Ask directly what growth means to them. Is it more responsibility, a title change, more pay, or different work? Their answer shapes your response.
- Stretch assignments: Give them ownership of a team project — floor walking shifts, buddy coaching, quality calibration, or process improvement tasks.
- Subject Matter Expert (SME) role: Nominate them as the team's SME for a product, queue, or skill area. This provides visibility and recognition without requiring a vacant TL role.
- Visible career pathway: Build a written development plan with milestones. Even if no role is available now, a credible timeline ('TL pipeline, targeting Q3') demonstrates the organisation's investment.
- Cross-team visibility: Involve them in cross-functional projects or management meetings where they can demonstrate their potential to senior stakeholders.

Q4 | SUDDEN UNDERPERFORMANCE

An agent who was once a consistent performer has declined sharply over 6 weeks. Metrics are down, attendance is irregular. What is your approach?

Model Answer

A sudden performance change in a previously consistent agent almost always has an underlying cause. The first step is to understand, not to judge.

- Private, empathetic 1-on-1: Create a safe space for the agent to share what is happening. Ask open questions: 'I've noticed some changes recently and I want to check in — how are you doing?'
- Explore root causes: Personal issues (health, family, financial stress), burnout, team conflict, or workplace dissatisfaction could all be contributing. Each has a different intervention.
- Agree a support plan: If there is a personal issue, explore EAP (Employee Assistance Programme), flexible scheduling, or a temporary adjusted target. Document the agreed support.
- Performance Improvement Plan (if no improvement): If after a reasonable support period there is no improvement, move to a formal PIP with SMART targets, a support structure, and a review timeline.

The distinction between a support plan and a PIP is intent — a support plan is designed to help, while a PIP is a formal performance management tool. Always exhaust the former before the latter.

First Call Resolution (FCR)

Resolving customer issues on first contact

04

DEFINITION

FCR measures the percentage of customer contacts resolved on the first interaction, without the customer needing to call back or be transferred for the same issue. It is one of the strongest predictors of both CSAT and operational efficiency.

FORMULA

$$\text{FCR \%} = (\text{Calls Resolved on First Contact} / \text{Total Calls Handled}) \times 100$$
 Industry benchmark: 70-79% is average; 80%+ is considered best-in-class.

Q1 | ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS

Your team's FCR drops from 82% to 68% within a month. No product change was made. What is your investigation plan?

Model Answer

A 14-point FCR drop is significant and warrants a structured root cause investigation before implementing any solution.

- Categorize repeat contacts: Pull data on customers who called back within 48–72 hours for the same issue. What are the top 3–5 repeat contact reasons? This is your primary diagnostic.
- Agent-level breakdown: Identify which agents have the lowest individual FCR rates. Is the drop concentrated in specific agents (training/coaching issue) or uniform across the team (process/system issue)?
- New agent cohort analysis: If new hires joined recently, their lower FCR during ramping is often the driver. Segment new vs. tenured agent FCR data separately.
- Call listening: Listen to 10–15 calls that resulted in a callback. Identify the moment of failure — was the issue not resolved correctly, not fully confirmed, or was the agent avoiding complex queries?
- Knowledge base audit: Check if a policy, FAQ, or process guide was updated but not communicated to the team, leaving agents with outdated information.

Present findings as a structured root cause report: category of failure, volume impact, agent(s) involved, and a prioritized action plan with owners and timelines.

Q2 | COACHING TRANSFERS

An agent consistently transfers calls they could resolve themselves. This is hurting FCR. How do you coach this behaviour?

Model Answer

Excessive transferring is typically driven by one of three root causes: knowledge gap, confidence deficit, or avoidance. Each requires a different coaching approach.

- Identify the root cause first: Listen to 5–10 calls the agent transferred. Were they genuinely outside their skill scope, or could the agent have resolved them with the right support?
- If it is a knowledge gap: Targeted upskilling sessions, knowledge base walkthroughs, and paired coaching with a senior agent on those specific query types.
- If it is a confidence issue: Role-play scenarios in a safe environment. Build a 'first attempt checklist' the agent can follow before deciding to transfer.
- If it is avoidance: Have a direct, honest conversation. Set a measurable target (e.g., reduce unnecessary transfers by 50% in 2 weeks) and make it part of their coaching plan.
- Reward first-contact resolutions: Acknowledge when the agent resolves a complex query without transferring. Positive reinforcement builds confidence faster than corrective feedback alone.

Q3 | PROCESS IMPROVEMENT

Customers are calling back within 48 hours for the same issue despite agents marking calls as resolved. What process improvements would you suggest?

Model Answer

This pattern indicates a systemic issue with resolution quality or verification, not just individual agent behaviour.

- Improve call closure technique: Train agents on the 3-step close: summarise the resolution, confirm the customer's understanding, and proactively address likely follow-up questions before the customer hangs up.
- Introduce a resolution confirmation step: Add a mandatory script line before ending the call — 'Is there anything else I can help you with today, and are you happy that this issue is fully resolved?'
- CRM note quality: Audit ACW notes on repeat-contact calls. If notes are vague or incomplete, agents handling the repeat contact cannot build on prior resolution attempts, causing duplication of effort.
- 48-hour repeat contact flag: Implement a system flag that alerts supervisors when a customer calls back within 48 hours for the same query type. This enables proactive coaching of the original agent.
- Calibration session: Run a team calibration using repeat-contact call examples. Define what 'fully resolved' looks like vs. what constitutes an incomplete resolution.

Customer Satisfaction (CSAT)

Measuring and improving the customer experience

05

FORMULA

$$\text{CSAT \%} = (\text{Number of Satisfied Responses} / \text{Total Survey Responses}) \times 100$$
 Satisfied = typically ratings of 4 or 5 on a 1-5 scale. Industry average: 75-85% depending on sector.

Q1 | SUDDEN CSAT DROP

CSAT drops by 12 points in a week across your team. Call volume and staffing are stable. What is your action plan?

Model Answer

A 12-point drop in one week is a significant signal that something has changed in either the customer experience, the agent behaviour, or the feedback environment.

- Verbatim analysis first: Pull all open-text survey comments from the affected period. Categorize the themes — is the feedback about agent tone, wait times, resolution quality, or product issues?
- Correlate with agent data: Identify if the drop is uniform across the team or driven by 2–3 specific agents. Agent-level CSAT breakdown is your most actionable diagnostic.
- Check for process or script changes: Was a new script, hold procedure, or escalation path introduced? Even minor changes can significantly affect how customers feel during the interaction.
- Call listening with calibration: Pull 10–15 calls from the lowest-rated interactions. Listen with a quality framework. Identify specific behaviours or moments that caused dissatisfaction.
- Urgent team calibration: Run a 30-minute team huddle using good vs. poor call examples. Reset expectations on empathy, resolution, and call closure standards.

Present findings to management within 48 hours with a root cause summary and a 2-week recovery plan with measurable milestones.

Q2 | AHT vs CSAT TRADE-OFF

One of your agents has the highest CSAT scores but also the highest AHT. How do you present this to senior management?

Model Answer

This is a strategic discussion about the relationship between efficiency and quality — not a simple performance problem.

- Frame it as a benchmark opportunity: This agent demonstrates what world-class customer experience looks like. Their CSAT score is not coincidental — it is a result of specific behaviours that can be replicated.
- Analyse what drives their quality: Review their calls to identify the specific behaviours causing high CSAT — empathy phrases, complete resolutions, proactive follow-up. These become your team coaching standards.
- Model the AHT improvement pathway: Present a coaching plan targeting the agent's AHT reduction in a specific component (e.g., ACW, hold time) without changing what drives their CSAT.
- Business case for quality: Model the cost of repeat contacts prevented by high CSAT vs. the capacity cost of higher AHT. In many cases, CSAT improvement delivers higher ROI than AHT reduction.

The message to management: 'This agent is our quality benchmark. We are working collaboratively to improve their efficiency without compromising the customer experience that makes them exceptional.'

Q3 | SURVEY COACHING

Agents are suspected of coaching customers to give 5-star ratings before the survey is sent. How do you address this?

Model Answer

Coaching customers on survey ratings is a form of data manipulation that undermines the organisation's ability to make informed decisions. It must be addressed directly.

- Audit call recordings: Identify specific instances where agents are prompting ratings. This gives you factual evidence rather than suspicion, which is essential for a fair conversation.
- Team education session: Without naming individuals initially, run a session explaining why authentic CSAT matters — business decisions on process, training, and investment are made based on this data.
- Clear policy communication: State explicitly that coaching customers on survey responses is a policy violation with specific consequences, and document this in the team's code of conduct.
- 1-on-1 with identified agents: Have a private, direct conversation with agents found to be coaching. Distinguish between accidental (thanking the customer for their time) and deliberate (telling them to rate 5) behaviour.
- Reframe CSAT incentives: If CSAT is tied to bonuses in a way that creates pressure to manipulate, raise this with management. Incentive design should reward genuine improvement, not gaming.

Customer Dissatisfaction (DSAT)

Identifying, analysing, and recovering from negative experiences

06

DEFINITION

DSAT is the percentage of customers who rated their experience as dissatisfied (typically 1-2 on a 5-point scale). It is a more actionable metric than CSAT for identifying failure points, as negative experiences tend to produce more detailed and specific feedback.

Q1 | PATTERN ANALYSIS

Your DSAT rate spikes every Monday morning. Volume is the same as other days. What would you investigate?

Model Answer

A day-specific DSAT pattern points to a structural or staffing issue tied to Monday conditions, not to agent behaviour alone.

- Weekend backlog effect: Customers who had unresolved issues over the weekend arrive on Monday morning already frustrated. The first agent they reach absorbs that frustration regardless of their performance.
- Post-weekend system issues: Are there known system delays, data sync issues, or maintenance windows that affect Monday service quality? Cross-check with IT and your WFM team.
- Monday shift composition: Are less experienced agents, higher proportions of new hires, or reduced TL coverage scheduled on Monday mornings? Staffing quality affects both resolution capability and tone.
- Self-service failure on weekends: If the IVR, chatbot, or website fails to resolve issues over the weekend, customers arrive at the call centre on Monday with compounded frustration.

Action: Run a Monday-specific call audit, correlate DSAT verbatims with time-of-day data, and adjust staffing or scheduling to add experienced agents on Monday mornings.

Q2 | AGENT-SPECIFIC DSAT

A customer submits a DSAT with a verbatim comment naming a specific agent for being dismissive. How do you handle this?

Model Answer

A named DSAT requires a balanced approach — protecting the customer's experience while ensuring the agent is treated fairly.

- Pull and listen to the call: Before any conversation with the agent, review the recording. Assess whether the customer's perception of 'dismissiveness' aligns with the actual interaction.
- Assess objectively: Was the agent genuinely dismissive, or was the customer's interpretation shaped by frustration about the issue itself? Both scenarios require different responses.
- Private coaching conversation: If the behaviour is validated, have a structured, non-punitive conversation. Play the relevant section of the call and ask the agent to reflect — 'How do you think the customer felt at this point?'
- Define the expected standard: Use specific examples of better phrasing. Role-play alternative approaches. Set a follow-up review date.
- Check for pattern: Is this an isolated incident or part of a trend? Pull the agent's last 30 DSAT calls for a trend assessment before deciding on the level of intervention.

Document the feedback, the coaching conversation, and the agreed improvement actions in the agent's performance record.

Q3 | SYSTEMIC DSAT

DSAT verbatim feedback consistently mentions long hold times and unresolved issues, not agent behaviour. What do you do?

Model Answer

When DSAT is driven by systemic failures rather than agent behaviour, coaching agents will not fix the problem. The intervention must be at the operational or process level.

- Build the business case: Compile the DSAT data, categorized verbatims, and trend over time into a clear presentation. Quantify the impact — repeat contacts generated, customer churn risk, revenue at stake.
- Identify the root causes: Long hold times suggest navigation issues, tool accessibility, or knowledge gaps. Unresolved issues suggest empowerment gaps (agents lacking authority to resolve) or process complexity.
- Propose specific solutions: Do not just escalate the problem — attach proposed fixes. For hold times: improve knowledge base, add quick-reference tools. For unresolved issues: review escalation thresholds, expand agent authority.
- Protect your agents: Make it explicit to management that the DSAT is a process or system failure, not an agent performance failure. Coaching agents for problems they cannot control damages morale and trust.

This situation demonstrates operational maturity — the ability to distinguish between agent-driven and system-driven problems is one of the most valued skills in a senior TL or operations manager role.

Performance Management

PIPs, consistency, team KPIs, and recognition

07

Q1 | PIP CONVERSATION

You need to put an agent on a Performance Improvement Plan. They are defensive and deny there is an issue. How do you conduct this conversation?

Model Answer

A PIP conversation with a resistant agent requires careful preparation, emotional regulation, and an unwavering focus on data over opinion.

- Prepare with data: Enter the conversation with specific, documented evidence — metric reports, call scores, attendance records. Never rely on general impressions.
- Open with structure, not accusation: 'I want to talk through your performance data over the last 8 weeks and share some concerns I have.' Avoid emotional language like 'you have been letting the team down.'
- Acknowledge their perspective: If the agent pushes back, say 'I hear that you see it differently. Can you walk me through your view?' Listen genuinely — there may be context you are missing.
- Return to data: After acknowledging, redirect: 'I understand your perspective, and I want to make sure we also look at the data together.' Reviewing the data together is more effective than presenting conclusions.
- SMART goals and support: Frame the PIP as a structured support tool, not a disciplinary end-point. Agree specific, measurable targets, the support you will provide, and the review timeline.

Close by asking: 'What support do you need from me to achieve these targets?' This shifts the dynamic from punitive to collaborative, which improves the probability of success.

Q2 | INCONSISTENT PERFORMANCE

An agent performs well when you are present but underperforms when you are away. How do you address this?

Model Answer

This behaviour pattern — sometimes called 'supervisor effect' — indicates the agent is capable of meeting standards but is choosing not to when accountability is perceived as lower.

- Lead with data from all shifts: Present performance data across observed and unobserved shifts side-by-side. This makes the pattern undeniable without relying on subjective observation.
- Discuss accountability and self-management: 'The standard I need from you is the same whether I am on the floor or not. Your metrics should reflect what you are capable of, not who is watching.'
- Use remote monitoring tools: Implement structured call listening from unobserved shifts. Share findings in coaching to show the agent that performance is always visible, not just when you are physically present.
- Peer accountability: Consider a buddy or senior agent check-in system during your absence. This distributes accountability without requiring your constant physical presence.
- Formal follow-up: If the pattern continues after the conversation, document it as a performance pattern and initiate a structured coaching plan with clear consequences.

Q3 | TEAM-WIDE KPI MISS

Your entire team misses KPIs for two consecutive months. Your manager asks you what went wrong. How do you respond?

Model Answer

The response to a team-wide performance failure must demonstrate accountability, analytical thinking, and a credible recovery plan.

- Own accountability: Begin by acknowledging your role as the team leader. Avoid deflecting to external factors as the primary explanation, even if they contributed.
- Present a structured root cause analysis: Categorize the contributing factors — staffing changes, product/process changes, training gaps, morale factors, or WFM planning issues. Use data to support each factor.
- Distinguish controllable from uncontrollable: Some factors (system outages, volume spikes) are outside your control. Others (coaching frequency, calibration quality, agent motivation) are within it. Be honest about both.
- Present a recovery plan: Outline specific actions, owners, timelines, and success metrics. A recovery plan must be time-bound — 'we will return to target within 6 weeks' with weekly milestones.

The key message: 'I take responsibility for the team's performance. Here is what I believe contributed, what I am doing about it, and how I will ensure it does not recur.' Managers respond to accountability paired with competence.

Q4 | RECOGNITION DILEMMA

You have budget for one 'best performer' reward this month, but two agents are tied on all metrics. What do you do?

Model Answer

This tests your judgment on fairness, team culture, and the purpose of recognition — not just metric-reading.

- Look beyond metrics: When quantitative scores are tied, examine qualitative factors — consistency over the month vs. a late surge, team contribution (helping colleagues, mentoring), attendance, and attitude during difficult periods.
- Consult quality scores: If QA scores differ between the two, use this as the tiebreaker. Quality is often under-weighted in pure metric comparisons.
- Split recognition creatively: If you genuinely cannot differentiate, consider one formal award and one public recognition (shoutout in team meeting, message to senior manager). Both agents feel valued without the budget being exceeded.
- Be transparent: Briefly explain to the team how the decision was made. Transparency builds trust in the recognition system and reduces resentment.

Avoid flipping a coin or defaulting to seniority. The recognition process is a leadership moment — how you decide communicates what your team values and what behaviours you reward.

Shrinkage & Formula

Understanding, calculating, and managing capacity loss

08

DEFINITION

Shrinkage is the percentage of scheduled work time during which agents are paid but unavailable to handle customer contacts. **PLANNED SHRINKAGE** includes: scheduled breaks, lunch, training sessions, team meetings, and coaching. **UNPLANNED SHRINKAGE** includes: absenteeism, late logins, system downtime, and unscheduled time off.

FORMULA

$\text{Shrinkage \%} = (\text{Total Shrinkage Hours} / \text{Total Scheduled Hours}) \times 100$
 $\text{Total Shrinkage} = \text{Planned Hours Lost} + \text{Unplanned Hours Lost}$
Example: 25 agents x 8 hrs = 200 hrs scheduled. If 44 hrs are lost to breaks, training, and absenteeism: $\text{Shrinkage} = (44 / 200) \times 100 = 22\%$
Staffing implication: To cover 200 productive hrs needed with 22% shrinkage, you must schedule: $\text{Required headcount} = \text{Productive hrs needed} / (1 - \text{Shrinkage \%}) = 200 / 0.78 = 256 \text{ hrs worth of agents}$

Q1 | CALCULATION

Your centre has 50 agents working 8-hour shifts. Daily shrinkage averages 22%. How many productive hours are actually available?

Model Answer

This is a direct application of the shrinkage formula.

- Total scheduled hours: 50 agents x 8 hours = 400 hours.
- Shrinkage hours lost: $400 \times 22\% = 88$ hours unavailable.
- Productive hours available: $400 - 88 = 312$ hours.
- Staffing implication: Workforce Management uses this to determine how many agents to roster vs. how many are actually needed on the phones. If you need 400 productive hours, you would need to schedule approximately 513 hours worth of agents ($400 / 0.78$) to account for the shrinkage.

Understanding shrinkage helps TLs and WFM avoid the common mistake of equating headcount with capacity. A team of 50 agents is not the same as 50 agents available to handle contacts.

Q2 | REDUCING UNPLANNED SHRINKAGE

Your unplanned shrinkage has risen to 18% versus a target of 10%. What steps do you take to bring it down?

Model Answer

Unplanned shrinkage is largely driven by absenteeism, late logins, and extended breaks. Each has a distinct intervention.

- Root cause breakdown: Analyse unplanned shrinkage by category. Is the primary driver absenteeism, late logins, or something else? The intervention must match the cause.
- Attendance management: Implement a clear return-to-work process for absences. Review patterns (same day each week? after specific shifts?) to identify potential disengagement or burnout signals.
- Schedule adherence tools: Use real-time adherence dashboards to flag agents who are off-queue without authorisation. Address immediately rather than at end of shift.
- Engagement interventions: High unplanned shrinkage often signals low engagement or burnout. Run stay interviews and team pulse checks to identify root causes beyond logistics.
- Incentivise attendance: Where HR policy allows, recognise teams or individuals with strong attendance records. A positive reinforcement approach is often more effective than punitive measures alone.

Target the 8% gap (18% vs 10%) in phases: address the top 1-2 categories driving the most hours first, then tackle secondary factors.

Q3 | TRAINING SCHEDULING

You need to plan a 2-hour mandatory product training for 30 agents during a high-volume day. How do you minimise the shrinkage impact?

Model Answer

Planning training on a high-volume day requires careful batching, timing, and WFM coordination.

- Batch into groups: Split 30 agents into 3 groups of 10. Each group attends a 2-hour session in rotation, ensuring 20 agents remain available at any given time.
- Schedule during low-volume windows: Use historical intraday volume data to identify the quietest 2-hour windows (typically mid-morning or early afternoon on most campaigns). Schedule each batch there.
- WFM coordination: Flag the training plan to WFM in advance. They can adjust the staffing model, flag the shrinkage uplift, and arrange contingency coverage if needed.
- Pre-brief agents: Ensure agents know the schedule in advance so break and lunch patterns can be adjusted around training slots.

Document the planned vs. actual shrinkage impact post-training. This data helps improve future training scheduling decisions.

Attrition & Formula

Measuring, understanding, and reducing agent turnover

09

TYPES OF ATTRITION

VOLUNTARY: Agent chooses to leave (better offer, burnout, relocation, career change). **INVOLUNTARY:** Organisation initiates the exit (termination, PIP failure, redundancy). **REGRETTED:** Loss of a high performer — costly and damaging to team capability. **NON-REGRETTED:** Planned exit of a consistently underperforming or non-compliant agent.

FORMULA

Monthly Attrition % = (Agents Who Left in the Month / Average Headcount) x 100
Average Headcount = (Opening Headcount + Closing Headcount) / 2
Example: 6 agents left. Opening headcount = 52, Closing = 48. Average = (52+48)/2 = 50. Attrition = (6 / 50) x 100 = 12% monthly attrition. Annualised Attrition = Monthly Attrition % x 12 (or sum 12 months for accuracy).

Q1 | SUDDEN EXITS

Three of your best agents resign in the same month citing 'lack of growth.' What immediate and long-term actions do you take?

Model Answer

Three simultaneous resignations from high performers is a critical retention signal that requires both immediate damage control and a structural response.

- Immediate — stay interviews: Within the next 5 business days, hold confidential 1-on-1 stay interviews with every remaining team member. Ask: 'What keeps you here? What would make you consider leaving?'
- Immediate — retention conversations: Identify the next 3–5 agents most at risk of leaving based on tenure, engagement signals, and informal feedback. Have proactive retention conversations.
- Escalate with data: Present the 3 exits to HR and senior management with the 'lack of growth' theme as the stated cause. Frame it as a systemic risk, not 3 isolated incidents.
- Long term — visible career paths: Work with HR to build and communicate a documented growth pathway — from agent to senior agent, SME, TL, quality coach, and beyond — with clear criteria for each step.
- Long term — stretch opportunities: While formal promotions are created, implement SME roles, project ownership, and cross-functional secondments as immediate growth outlets.

The cost of replacing a high performer is typically 1.5–2x their annual salary when you factor in recruitment, onboarding, and performance ramp time. Retention investment is always cheaper.

Q2 | EXIT DATA

Exit interview data shows 60% of agents who left cited 'team leader behaviour' as the primary reason. You are the TL. How do you respond?

Model Answer

This is one of the most personally challenging feedback scenarios a TL can face. The response must demonstrate self-awareness, professionalism, and a genuine commitment to change.

- Do not get defensive: Defensive responses in this context signal a lack of self-awareness, which compounds the original problem. The appropriate initial response is: 'Thank you for sharing this with me. I want to understand it better.'
- Request specific examples: Ask HR for specific, anonymised verbatims from exit interviews. General feedback like 'team leader behaviour' is not actionable without specifics.
- Self-audit: Review your recent interactions, coaching conversations, communication style, and any decisions that may have caused friction. Be honest about what you find.
- 360-degree feedback: Request a structured 360 from your current team (anonymous format through HR) to identify patterns. This demonstrates courage and a genuine desire to improve.
- Coaching from your manager: Engage your own line manager or an HR business partner for coaching. Model the same development behaviours you expect from your agents.

The TLs who respond to this feedback with accountability and a structured development plan are the ones who build the strongest long-term teams. This scenario is a professional growth opportunity, not a career-ending event.

Q3 | HIGH ATTRITION QUARTER

Your attrition is 25% this quarter versus a 12% target. Your manager asks you to present a recovery plan. What does it include?

Model Answer

A recovery plan for high attrition must address root causes, not just symptoms, and must be credible to leadership with specific timelines and metrics.

- Attrition breakdown: Segment by voluntary/involuntary, regretted/non-regretted, tenure band (new hire vs. tenured agents), and shift pattern. Each segment has different drivers and interventions.
- Root cause analysis: Based on exit interviews and stay interview data, identify the top 3 drivers. Common causes: pay competitiveness, management relationship, workload/burnout, lack of growth, commute/flexibility.
- Hiring pipeline: High attrition requires a parallel response on the supply side. Work with TA (Talent Acquisition) to accelerate the pipeline, improve quality of hire screening, and strengthen onboarding to reduce early-tenure exits.
- Engagement interventions: Launch a structured engagement programme — recognition schemes, flexible scheduling, team social activities, and transparent communication about the organisation's direction.
- Short-term metrics: Set weekly attrition tracking with leading indicators (resignation notices received, employees at risk flagged in stay interviews, engagement pulse scores).

Present the plan in 3 horizons: 30-day quick wins (engagement, stay interviews, pipeline), 60-day structural changes (career paths, manager coaching), 90-day target (return to 12% annualised rate).

Q4 | RETENTION CONVERSATION

A high performer tells you informally they have received an external offer. You cannot match the salary. What do you do?

Model Answer

A salary counter-offer that cannot be matched forces a conversation about total value, not just base pay. Research consistently shows that counter-offers without structural change result in the agent leaving within 6 months anyway.

- Listen first: Before proposing anything, understand the full picture. Is the external offer purely about money, or are there other factors — role type, flexibility, commute, culture?
- Explore non-monetary value: Map what your organisation offers that the external role may not — stability, team relationships, career path, brand, work-life balance, benefits, and development opportunities.
- Make a credible case for the future: If a promotion or pay review is genuinely on the horizon (within 3–6 months), present this specifically with a timeline. Vague promises accelerate exits, not retention.
- Be honest: If you cannot match the offer and cannot offer a near-term improvement, say so directly. Respecting the agent's decision builds trust and may result in a positive departure — they are more likely to return or refer others.
- Escalate if possible: If the agent is genuinely critical to the team, escalate to HR or your manager immediately with the business case for a salary exception.

Document the conversation regardless of outcome. If they stay, set a 30-day check-in. If they leave, use the information to strengthen your retention strategy for the rest of the team.

Good luck with your interview. These answers are starting points — the strongest candidates adapt them to their own real experiences.